Mission Doctor in the Orient

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CHINESE medicine was merely heathen superstition to most western doctors who went out to China in the early Nineteen Hundreds to carry enlightenment to a backward people. The young Johns Hopkins graduate, Edward H. Hume, who

DOCTORS EAST, DOCTORS WEST. By Edward H. Hume. 278 pp. New York: W. W. Norton & Co. $3.75.

started a hospital in Changsha in 1905 for the Yale University Mission, had a different point of view. He describes his book as "the personal record of how one American doctor discovered that medicine was a builder of bridges between nations and cultures." The unique thing about the bridge he built was that from the very beginning it was made for two-way traffic.

"Doctors East, Doctors West" should be read by every young person going to China to work, or to any other foreign country for that matter, not for the information it contains (which is a lot), nor for the advice it offers (it doesn't offer any), but as an object lesson in attitude. Dr. Hume was the first doctor to attempt to practice western medicine in Changsha, a city of strong and ancient traditions, where foreigners were still suspected and feared. When I first went to China, fifteen years later, I met many American doctors who lived in two or three story replicas of American houses towering against

tradition over a one-story Chinese city. They worked in sanitary and terrifying western hospitals full of patients clad in white garments suggestive of Chinese funeral garb, and from none of them did I hear any suggestion that Chinese doctoring was anything but superstition or that Chinese drugs were anything but witches' brews with which they wished no truck. When Dr. Hume arrived in Changsha he rented a Chinese inn, well thought of and familiar, and he made every effort to do things in the Chinese way, introducing only very gradually and with great care practices that might seem strange and frightening to his patients. It seemed perfectly natural to him that the Chinese should have their own superstitions and seemingly irrational customs, just as we have, and he discovered that many of them were more rational than they at first seemed.

He came to have great confidence in the competence of the traditional Chinese doctors, who, without benefit of scientific knowledge, without dissection or microscopes or laboratories, were amazingly skillful in diagnosing and curing disease, sometimes more skillful than he was with all his scientific training. He tells of examining a very ill woman and informing her husband that an abortion was imperative. The horrified mother-in-law hastily summoned a Chinese doctor, who prescribed medicine; the symptoms disappeared, and six months later she had a healthy son.

Dr. Hume was impressed by the fact that all well-educated Chinese had received training in the principles of medicine and were familiar with the medical classics. The mother of one of his early typhoid fever patients showed him a "Treatise on Typhoid Fever" published about A. D. 196 so accurately written that even "Osler could hardly have given a clearer picture." The treatment recommended by this early Chinese doctor also resembled Osler's, although both men differed from their contemporaries.

Since wealthy Chinese patients believed that the more physicians of different schools they could summon the better, Dr. Hume was often called on cases where Chinese doctors were also being consulted. The doctors usually visited the patient one at a time, but on at least one occasion he was called in consultation with a famous Chinese physician and was delighted to be able to observe his methods. He took pains to learn the ways these doctors had of inspiring confidence, such as the long and careful reading of the pulse, in both wrists, in which the Chinese put much faith, and the carrying in his bag of a Chinese translation of his own medical "classic," Osler's "Practice of Medicine," so that he could reinforce his diagnosis and advice by referring the family of his patient to a classical authority for his position.

With things familiar to the Chinese, such as vaccination or a cataract operation, he could proceed much as he would in America. In other things, such as anaesthesia, which were strange to them, he would be at great pains to understand their fears and respect their sensibilities. He writes of one little

patient who was very ill with smallpox: "We found a thin red garment with which to cover the boy's chest and hung red curtains in the windows. That I did not insist on white was a relief to the mother."

Dr. Hume was one of the first Americans to realize that many of the strange herbs and concoctions in a Chinese apothecary shop had been discovered empirically to have therapeutic value centuries before the west knew of their scientific use. He was impressed to learn, for instance, that the Chinese had long used seaweeds containing iodine for the treatment of goiter, ephedrine for coughs and influenza, chaulmoogra oil for leprosy, and that fish livers were good for anemia and tuberculosis. He became much interested in the study of Chinese medicine, and in a book called "The Chinese Way in Medicine," which he published in 1940, has given us in much more detail the fascinating results of this study.

A landmark in the development of the Yale medical mission was the arrival in 1910 of Dr. Yen, a young Chinese physician trained at Yale. Dr. Hume welcomed him eagerly, not only because he would greatly relieve his burden of work but because he believed enthusiastically in the cooperation between Americans and Chinese for which his hospital had always stood. He was therefore much disturbed at the aloofness of the other doctors at a missions conference to which he took him. One of the British doctors said to Dr. Hume, "Do you mean to tell me that your society in America has sent out a Chinese to be your colleague? * * * Why, it is simply unprecedented."

THE simple hospital which Dr. Hume started in a Chinese inn grew under his guidance into a large institution with a medical college and a school for nurses. During all the years of Chinese revolution he worked to make it a genuine Chinese institution. A few years after the government became established in Nanking the medical college became a national institution, and Dr. Hume resigned his administrative position. He was pleased that a Changsha paper said: "Educators in Changsha are grateful that Dr. Hume has based his resignation on the expectation that his tasks will be carried forward by Chinese administrators, who are now thoroughly trained and competent."

On every page Dr. Hume's story bears witness to the truth of his book's last sentence, "Only those can enter effectively into her life who approach China's citadel by way of friendship."